

PELICAN BAY POLICE DEPARTMENT
HOMICIDE DIVISION — EIGHTH DISTRICT
715 South Broad Avenue, New Orleans, LA 70119
(504) 658-6080

WITNESS STATEMENT

Case No.: PBPB-2026-034532 | Document No.: 08

Witness Name: TANYA NICOLE RIOS

DOB / Age / Sex / Race: 11/03/1996 / 28 / Female / Hispanic

Address: 3344 Magazine St., Apt. 2, New Orleans, LA 70115

Phone: 504-555-0512

Occupation: Senior Bartender, The Rusty Anchor (712 Bourbon Street)

Date/Time of Statement: October 4, 2025 — 05:20 AM

Location of Interview: Office at 712 Bourbon Street (back office)

Interviewing Detective: Det. Yvette Landry, Badge #1887

Witnessing Officer: Officer Roland Martin, Badge #3318

Recording: Audio recorder PBPB-AR-1144 (file 10-04-003)

Witness was advised of the homicide and that she was not a suspect. Witness appeared shaken but composed. Witness declined an offer for a victim-witness advocate to be present but accepted water and a brief break before beginning.

Q: Ms. Acosta, what time did you start your shift?

A: Six PM. I was on through close. I'm normally the closer on Fridays.

Q: When did you first notice the man we're calling Damari tonight?

A: Right around 11:45. He came in by himself. Sat at the corner of the bar. Ordered an Abita Amber. Real polite, said please and thank you. He had a small notebook he was writing in.

Q: Did he say what he was doing in New Orleans?

A: Yeah. I asked him, just chatty bartender stuff. He said he was a writer, working on a piece. He said it kind of casual, like he didn't want to make a big thing of it.

Q: Did he ask you any specific questions?

A: Yeah. About forty minutes in, when it was a little quieter, he asked me if I'd been working in August when 'that thing happened next door.' Those were his words. I knew right away what he meant — the guy that got beat up behind Marie's. I told him I'd been on that night but I didn't see anything. Which is true.

Q: What did he do then?

A: He nodded. He didn't push. He asked if I knew if any of the guys involved still came around. I — (pause) — I told him I didn't know who was 'involved' in what. Because I don't, officially. He kind of smiled and said something like 'fair enough.' And he ordered another beer.

Q: Were Trent Cormier, Marco Pellegrino, or Kyle — I think his last name is Robicheaux — in the bar tonight?

A: Yes. All three. They came in around 10. Sat at the back high-top all night. Drinking Crown and Cokes, mostly Trent. Marco was on shots. Kyle I think was nursing beers — he doesn't drink as hard as the other two.

Q: Did any of the three of them interact with the man at the bar?

A: Not directly. But I noticed Marco staring. A couple times. The kind of stare that makes me, like, pay attention as a bartender. And at one point — this was maybe around 1 AM? — I heard Trent say to Marco, kind of loud, 'shut up, dude,' the way you say it when somebody's about to say something they shouldn't. They got a little quieter after that. They were watching him.

Q: Did you tell anyone, or do anything about that?

A: No. I just kept an eye out. I thought maybe Marco knew him from somewhere, or it was a — you know, a race thing. I was hoping nothing would happen. We get tension sometimes and most of the time it's nothing.

Q: When did Damari Thornton leave the bar?

A: Around 2:25. He'd been on his phone for a minute. Then he closed his notebook, paid his tab, left a five-dollar tip, and walked out. He went out the back.

Q: The back staff door into the alley?

A: Yeah. That surprised me a little. Most customers go out the front. But it's not unheard of. The street can be a mess at 2 AM, the alley is sometimes quicker if you're heading east.

Q: And the three regulars — Trent, Marco, Kyle — what did they do?

A: (pause, exhales) They followed. Not right away. Maybe — a minute? A minute and a half? Trent got up, said something to Marco, and they all three went out the back. Same door. Trent had this — there's a long souvenir bat he keeps behind the bar sometimes. Like a wooden mini-bat, but full size. He'd brought it in earlier with some boxes — he runs the bar supply that delivers to us. He picked it up on his way out.

Q: Did you see him pick up the bat?

A: Yes. He grabbed it from where it was leaning against the wall by the back door. I — God. I should have said something. I thought it was just bravado.

Q: Did you say anything?

A: No. I just kept working. There were a few people left to close out. About ten minutes after that I heard sirens, but sirens on Bourbon Street aren't unusual.

Q: Did any of the three come back into the bar?

A: No. Not while I was there. I closed out around 3:10 and locked up. They never came back.

Q: Did you take any photos or videos at any point tonight?

A: No. But Mr. Olivier's camera over the back door — that's been running. You'd see them go out. And come back, maybe, if they did, after I left.

Q: Ms. Acosta, would you be willing to identify these three regulars in a photo array?

A: Yes. I'd be willing. I want to do that.

END OF STATEMENT — 06:08 AM

Witness was advised of the victim-witness program and provided a contact card. She declined to be relocated but agreed to keep the department informed of any contact attempts by individuals named in this statement.

Witness Signature: _____ Marisol Acosta

Interviewing Detective: _____ Det. R. Landry #1887

Witness to Statement: _____ Officer J. Martin #3318